

The Forest in the World's Wisdom

A Comparative Analysis of Spiritual Systems and Worldviews

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Grounding document of the Carpathian OER Commons, published as a working draft and open to co-creation. It speaks from conviction, and its facts have not yet been checked against their sources as the foundations paper's were; corrections are welcome. That traditions share a shape says something about people; it is not evidence that a method works (foundations paper, Section 6). Points of Hutsul practice are marked [for the elders].

v0.6, 2026-09-27: prepared for publication — Hutsul points marked for the elders; the synoptic table set out as a list.

Companion document to "The Eco-Spiritual Philosophy of the Living Forest." It surveys the world's spiritual systems and worldviews as kin to the Forest School's practice. The rule of the survey is stated at its end and governs throughout: the school honours these traditions by parallel, never by imitation; the local tradition leads; nothing is transplanted, and every source is named.

I. The Taproot — The Hutsul and Ukrainian Folk Worldview

The philosophy of the Living Forest grows from this ground and no other. The Hutsul highlands hold a deep animism: mountains, springs, and trees as living presences; the high pasture as a lived-with world, never a wilderness apart. The tradition meets even death in community — the night vigils in which grief is confronted together through games, laughter, and song until the fear of death is defeated. Beneath and around it lies the wider Ukrainian folk layer, where the old earth-faith and Christianity have long lived braided together: the green holidays when homes and churches fill with branches and grasses, the midsummer fires and water rites, songs that bless the field and the year. What the school draws is everything — this is not a source among sources but the soil in which all the others are planted, and its carriers, the elders of the valley, hold the gate on its use. [for the elders]

II. The Old Ways of Northern and Eastern Europe

Before the surveys cross the oceans, they cross the Baltic — for nowhere is the old European bond to place buried more shallowly than among the peoples of the northern and eastern seas, and nowhere in Europe did it survive longer in the open.

The Baltic peoples — Lithuania, Latvia, and the old Prussian coast. The last peoples of Europe to hold their earth-faith openly: Lithuania accepted Christianity only at the close of the fourteenth century, and the old ways never fully left. Sacred groves and holy oaks stood at the heart of worship — the oak as the thunder-god's tree, felled only at peril — and the world was sung: the dainas, the vast ocean of Latvian and Lithuanian folk songs, hold the sun, the seasons, the field-work, and the soul's passages in hundreds of thousands of four-line verses, a whole cosmology kept alive in song by grandmothers. And in living memory the singing held: the Singing Revolution of the Baltic nations faced down an empire

with massed song and won. What the school draws: the deepest European confirmation of its own practice — that a people's bond to land can be *kept in song* across centuries of pressure, and that singing together is not decoration but survival, resistance, and victory. The valley's own singing and the Baltic *dainas* are one family.

The Finnic north — Finland, Karelia, Estonia. In the Kalevala songs, the sage does not fight the world into shape; he *sings* it into being, and power over any thing comes from knowing and singing its origin. The forest was the church: the Estonian *hiis* — sacred groves — are tended to this day, and the old reverence for the bear returned even its bones to the forest with honour. The bond has passed into modern law as everyman's right: the freedom of every person to walk, gather, and be at home in the land, paired with the duty to leave it unharmed. What the school draws: that to know a being's origin is to be in relationship with it — every pattern card asking "what is this, and where does it come from" walks the singer's path — and that belonging to land can be written into a modern country's law as both right and care.

The Norse world. The cosmos itself was a tree: Yggdrasil, roots in memory and depth, trunk in the living present, crown in the heavens — the very three-fold the school's children learn to read in every tree. The land was alive with *landvættir*, the land spirits: ships approaching home shores removed their dragon-head prows so as not to affright them — arrival, even armed arrival, made gentle before the spirits of place. Law itself was spoken under the open sky, the assembly gathered outdoors on the land it governed. And wisdom, in the deepest Norse story, was won on the tree. What the school draws: the tree as the readable cosmos; the practice of arriving gently on any land; and the circle under open sky as the oldest parliament. One Norse path the school honours and does not walk: the solitary night-vigil and the ordeal on the tree belong to the tradition's adults — the school's children cross every threshold accompanied.

The Celts. The grove — *nemeton* — was the sanctuary; wells and springs were doorways of the holy; the year turned on threshold nights when the veil between worlds thinned. The learned orders trained for as much as twenty years in the forest itself, wisdom carried wholly in memory and verse — Europe's original forest school. The trees were even an alphabet: in ogham, each letter bears a tree's name, so that to learn one's letters was to learn the forest, and the land was literally the text. Early Irish law ranked the trees in classes and fined their wounding — nobles of the wood, protected by statute. What the school draws: the oldest European precedent for everything it is — a school held in the forest, a curriculum written in trees, thresholds kept with ceremony, and the law itself standing guard over the wood.

III. The Peoples of the Urals, Taiga, Tundra, and Steppe

East of the old European ways, across the Urals and into the taiga and tundra, live nations whose lands lie within the borders of today's Russian state. One distinction governs this section absolutely: these are the traditions of peoples, not of the state that contains them. Most of these nations were colonised by the

same empire Ukraine has known — their languages suppressed, their shamans persecuted, their ceremonies driven underground in the Soviet decades — and their survival is kin to Ukraine's own. The school honours peoples, never empires.

The Mari. In the forests of the middle Volga, the Mari keep Europe's last openly practised grove-faith: the *küsoto*, sacred groves — hundreds still active — where the community gathers for prayer ceremonies led by traditional priests, as it has through every century of pressure. What the school draws: living proof, inside this very decade, that a grove-faith can survive empire, church, and modernity in the open — the *hiis* and the *nemeton* not as memory but as neighbour.

The Khanty and Mansi. The Ob-Ugrian peoples — the closest linguistic kin of the Hungarians, Finns, and Estonians — hold the bear in deepest reverence, and their bear festival meets the gravest of occasions with songs, stories, and games played through the nights. What the school draws: startling kinship with the valley's own vigils — the same deep structure, a community answering death and awe with game and song — arising independently at the two ends of the Finno-Ugric world.

The Nenets. On the tundra of the far north, life moves with the reindeer as it does in Sápmi: land as partner, the herd as calendar, belonging carried in movement rather than walls. What the school draws: the second witness, beside the Sámi, that no landscape is too hard to be home when it is met as kin.

The Evenki. The taiga people of the great forest gave the world its very word: "shaman" entered every language from the Evenki tongue. Theirs is the archetypal accompanied crossing — the guided passage between worlds, made on behalf of the community. What the school draws: the vocabulary of the oldest human learning-shape comes from this forest; the school walks the shape's gentle half — accompanied, never alone, never through ordeal — and knows where the word for it was born.

The Sakha, and the peoples of Altai, Tuva, and Buryatia. In the Sakha epic of *Olonkho* — recognised among the world's oral masterpieces — the cosmos stands as *Aal Luuk Mas*, the great world tree; the *ysyakh* festival greets the returning sun. In the Altai mountains and across the steppe, the eternal sky is revered above sacred peaks, travellers add stones to the *oboo* cairns at passes, and in *khoomi* throat-singing a single voice sounds the river, the wind, and the mountain at once. What the school draws: a third cosmos-as-tree beside *Yggdrasil* and the tenet of roots, trunk, and canopy; small acts of reverence at the thresholds of travel; and one more witness that a people's land is held, and healed, in song.

IV. Turtle Island — The Indigenous Nations of North America

No single worldview covers the hundreds of distinct nations of the land many of its peoples call Turtle Island; the school listens to teachings those nations themselves have chosen to share publicly, and names them by nation.

The Thanksgiving Address (Haudenosaunee). The "words before all else": before any gathering proceeds, greetings and thanks are spoken to the people, the waters, the plants, the animals, the winds, the sun, moon, and stars — until the minds of those gathered are one. What the school draws: its Morning Circle of gratitude stands in unknowing parallel to this ancient protocol — gratitude not as feeling but as *practice*, spoken in community, ordering the day before the day begins.

The Seventh Generation principle (Haudenosaunee). Decisions weighed by their effect on the seventh generation to come. What the school draws: the whole architecture of cohort inheritance — trees planted for children not yet born, a record handed forward — is this principle at the scale of a mountainside; children practise seventh-generation thinking with their hands.

All My Relations (Lakota: mitákuye oyás'ín). The prayer-word that names the whole world as family: every being related, the human one relative among many. What the school draws: its refusal of "wilderness," its circle of care in which forest, child, elder, and community are members of one body — kinship as ecology's true name.

The Honourable Harvest (as taught by Robin Wall Kimmerer, Potawatomi). Never take the first; never take more than half; ask permission; use everything taken; give a gift in return for what is given. What the school draws: its ethic for every act of gathering — seed, branch, water, even knowledge from an elder — taking with asking, using with respect, returning more than was taken.

V. Indigenous Kin Across the World

Aboriginal Australia — Country and the songlines. Country is kin: a living relative to be cared for, not a resource. Knowledge of land is held in songlines — routes walked and sung, where the song is the map and the law. What the school draws: the pattern language of place is a young cousin of this oldest practice — knowing a land by walking it, naming it, and singing its knowledge forward so the next traveller can follow.

Aotearoa — the Māori way. Whakapapa binds people and the natural world into one genealogy — the forest is ancestor, not property; kaitiakitanga names the duty of guardianship that flows from that kinship. In law, Aotearoa has followed the worldview to its conclusion: the forest Te Urewera and the Whanganui River are legal persons. What the school draws: guardianship as inherited duty rather than chosen hobby — the child as kaitiaki of their own mountainside — and proof that a worldview can reshape even the law of states.

The Andes — Pachamama and ayni. The living earth-mother receives and gives; ayni, sacred reciprocity, orders human life — help given must circulate, gifts return as gifts. Sumak kawsay, the good life, means living well *with*, never at the expense of. What the school draws: ayni is the toloka's southern twin — the same circulating labour of kinship — and confirms that the school's economy of care belongs to a worldwide family of reciprocal economies.

Sápmi — the Sámi way. Life moved with the reindeer across tundra and forest treats land as partner in survival; the joik does not sing *about* a person, animal, or place — it sings them, presents them, keeps them present. What the school draws: song as a way of holding beings and places in memory and presence — a northern kin to the valley's own singing — and the tundra's lesson that there is no landscape too hard to be home.

Africa — ubuntu and the sacred groves. Ubuntu: a person is a person through other persons — being itself is relational. Across the continent, sacred groves such as the Yoruba forest of Osun-Osogbo have been protected for centuries because the sacred and the ecological were never separate categories. What the school draws: its deepest sentence — care circulating until no one is only giver or receiver — is ubuntu extended to the land; and the groves prove that reverence is the oldest and most effective conservation policy on earth.

VI. The Asian Ways

Shinto and shinrin-yoku (Japan). Nature as sacred space alive with kami; forest bathing as cleansing of body and spirit, now clinically studied. What the school draws: sensory immersion as practice — silent walks, trees met as living beings capable of absorbing pain — the tenet of Bathing in Life.

Daoism (China). The living flow of the world; naturalness; wu-wei, action through non-striving; water and softness as true strength. What the school draws: its manner — patient observation, adaptation to rhythm, the forest and the child each allowed to work at their own pace; the gardener's restraint as a spiritual discipline.

Buddhism. Mindfulness as bare attention; interbeing — the teaching that nothing exists separately, the tree in the paper, the cloud in the tree; impermanence held without despair. What the school draws: the quality of attention in its observation practices, and the composting movement's deepest logic — that what passes feeds what comes, and letting go is a form of care.

The Vedic and village traditions of India. Sacred groves (devrai and their many regional names) protected as the gods' own; ahimsa, non-harm, as the first ethic; and in living memory the Chipko movement, in which village women embraced trees with their bodies to stop the axes. What the school draws: the knowledge that children defending a forest stand in a long line of ordinary people whose care became protection — reverence as resistance, embodied.

VII. The Abrahamic Ways

Christianity — and first the churches of this valley. The Orthodox and Greek-Catholic traditions that hold the Carpathians carry a deep theology of creation: the world as icon of its maker, blessed with water and branch through the year's feasts; the hesychast practice of stillness and watchfulness of heart; and in

the wider church, from the saint of Assisi who called the creatures brother and sister to the encyclical *Laudato Si'* on care for our common home, an unbroken green thread. What the school draws: confidence that its philosophy stands *beside* the faith of the families it serves, not against it — reverence for creation is the church's own inheritance, and the school's silence, gratitude, and care are practices a believing family recognises as friendly ground.

Judaism. Bal tashchit — the command not to destroy wantonly, rooted in the Torah's protection of fruit trees even in war; shmita, the sabbath of the land, a rest every seventh year; Tu B'Shvat, the new year of the trees, when planting is celebration. What the school draws: rhythm as sacred law — even the land must rest — and the oldest legal protection of trees in wartime, written three thousand years before this war.

Islam. The human as khalifa — trustee, not owner, of the earth; mizan, the balance set in creation that must not be transgressed; the teaching that one who plants a tree from which any creature eats has given charity. What the school draws: stewardship as trusteeship — the land held in care for its true owner and for those to come — and the planting of a tree as an act of generosity that outlives the planter.

VIII. The Modern Convergence

Biophilia and eco-spirituality. The scientific hypothesis that humans carry an innate need for connection with living systems, and the growing practice of spirituality expressed through care rather than dogma. What the school draws: its plainest creed — a practical faith of hands in the soil — now speakable in the language of research as well as reverence.

Deep ecology. The philosophical position that the living world has worth in itself, not only as human resource, and that the self, fully understood, extends into the web of relations that sustain it. What the school draws: the intellectual articulation of what the traditions above have always practised — and a bridge language for partners who arrive through philosophy rather than faith.

The rights of nature. From Aotearoa's forest-person to Ecuador's constitution, the world's law has begun to say what the old worldviews always said: the living world is a subject, not only an object. What the school draws: evidence, for funders and sceptics, that the worldview it practises with children is not nostalgia — it is where the world is going.

IX. The Common Patterns

Read together, the traditions do not blur into sameness; they show a recurring deep structure, and the school is built on it:

- **Kinship, not wilderness.** Everywhere the oldest worldviews refuse the cut between human and nature: relations, ancestors, Country, kami, creation — never "environment."
- **Reciprocity as law.** Ayni, toloka, the Honourable Harvest, ubuntu, khalifa's trust: taking obliges giving; care must circulate or the world sickens.
- **Gratitude as protocol.** Not a mood but a practice with a form — words before all else, grace, blessing, the morning circle.
- **Land as teacher and text.** Songlines, pattern languages, the ogham letters named for trees, the tree's three laws: the ground itself is the curriculum, and sometimes the alphabet.
- **Song and ceremony where words fail.** Grief, threshold, and triumph are carried in the body — vigil, joik, lament, dance — in every tradition that has survived hard history.
- **Long time.** Seventh generations, shmita cycles, cathedral groves: the traditions think in tree-time, and teach it.
- **The accompanied crossing.** Into the forest, the tundra, the mountain — with a guide, and back with a gift. The oldest shape of learning on earth.

That this structure recurs from the Carpathians to the Baltic and across the Urals, from Turtle Island to Aotearoa, is the strongest evidence the school's philosophy could ask for: it is not inventing a way of being; it is rejoining one — humanity's oldest and most widely shared.

X. Synoptic View

The survey condensed to one view, in the form of the school's own founding concept: each system, its core philosophy, and what the Forest School draws from it.

- **Hutsul worldview and Ukrainian folk layer.** Core: animate highlands; grief met in community through vigil, game, and song; earth-faith and Christianity braided. Drawn: the taproot — grief-forms, singing, dance, the elders' authority over all use. [for the elders]
- **Baltic peoples (Lithuania, Latvia, old Prussia).** Core: sacred groves and holy oaks; cosmology kept in the dainas; song as national survival. Drawn: land-bond kept in song across centuries; singing together as survival, resistance, victory.
- **Finnic north (Finland, Karelia, Estonia).** Core: world sung into being; power through knowing origins; hiis groves; everyman's right. Drawn: knowing origins as relationship — the pattern card's question; belonging to land as right and duty.

- **Norse world.** Core: Yggdrasil, the cosmos as tree; landvættir, spirits of place; law spoken under open sky. Drawn: the tree as readable cosmos (roots, trunk, crown); arriving gently on any land; the circle outdoors.
- **Celts.** Core: nemeton groves; ogham tree-alphabet; thin-place thresholds; twenty-year forest schooling. Drawn: Europe's original forest school; the land as literal text; thresholds kept with ceremony.
- **Mari (middle Volga).** Core: küsoto sacred groves still openly practised; ceremonies led by traditional priests. Drawn: living proof a grove-faith survives empire and modernity in the open.
- **Udmurt (Ural foothills).** Core: kuala clan shrines; lud groves; village religion held longest in Europe. Drawn: the sacred at household scale — reverence a homestead school can live.
- **Komi (northern Urals).** Core: forest-spirit world; Perm animal-style bronzes; keepers of Europe's largest primeval forest. Drawn: what reverence preserves; human and forest as one figure.
- **Bashkirs (southern Urals).** Core: epic of Ural-batyr — water of life given to the land, his body become the mountains; wild-hive forest beekeeping. Drawn: a life given so the land lives; covenant of people, tree, and creature; mountain-reverence and faith in one God together.
- **Khanty and Mansi (Ob-Ugrians).** Core: bear reverence; the bear festival's nights of songs, stories, and games. Drawn: kinship with the valley's vigils — awe and grief answered in community with game and song.
- **Nenets (tundra).** Core: life moved with the reindeer; land as partner, belonging carried in movement. Drawn: with the Sámi, witness that no landscape is too hard to be home.
- **Evenki (taiga).** Core: source of the world's word "shaman"; the guided crossing made for the community. Drawn: the accompanied crossing's homeland; the school walks its gentle half — never alone, never ordeal.
- **Sakha; Altai, Tuva, Buryatia.** Core: Aal Luuk Mas world tree; eternal sky; oboo cairns; khoomei singing the land. Drawn: a third cosmos-as-tree; reverence at travel's thresholds; land held and healed in song.
- **Haudenosaunee (Turtle Island).** Core: Thanksgiving Address — words before all else; Seventh Generation decision-making. Drawn: gratitude as spoken protocol (Morning Circle); planting for children of children not yet born.
- **Lakota (Turtle Island).** Core: mitákuye oyás'iy — all my relations; the world as family. Drawn: the refusal of "wilderness"; the circle of care as kinship.
- **Potawatomi teaching (Turtle Island).** Core: the Honourable Harvest — ask, take less than half, use all, give back. Drawn: the school's ethic for every act of taking — seed, branch, water, knowledge.
- **Aboriginal Australia.** Core: Country as kin; songlines — knowledge walked and sung. Drawn: the pattern language's oldest cousin — land known by walking, naming, singing forward.

- **Māori (Aotearoa).** Core: whakapapa — one genealogy with nature; kaitiakitanga — guardianship; forest as legal person. Drawn: the child as guardian by inheritance; proof a worldview can reshape law.
- **Andean peoples.** Core: Pachamama; ayni — sacred reciprocity; sumak kawsay — living well with. Drawn: ayni as the toloka's southern twin; the economy of circulating care.
- **Sámi (Sápmi).** Core: land as partner in survival; the joik sings beings present. Drawn: song holding beings and places in memory; no landscape too hard to be home.
- **African traditions; ubuntu.** Core: a person is a person through other persons; sacred groves protected for centuries. Drawn: care circulating until no one is only giver or receiver; reverence as conservation.
- **Shinto and shinrin-yoku (Japan).** Core: nature as sacred space alive with kami; forest bathing as cleansing. Drawn: sensory immersion; silent walks; trees as living beings capable of absorbing pain.
- **Daoism (China).** Core: the living flow; naturalness; wu-wei — action through non-striving. Drawn: patient observation; adapting to rhythm; the gardener's restraint; softness as strength.
- **Buddhism.** Core: bare attention; interbeing; impermanence held without despair. Drawn: the quality of attention in observation; composting as letting-go that feeds what comes.
- **Vedic and village India.** Core: sacred groves; ahimsa; Chipko — bodies embracing trees against the axes. Drawn: reverence as embodied protection; children defending forest stand in a long line.
- **Christianity (the valley's churches first).** Core: creation as icon; blessing with water and branch; stillness of heart; care for the common home. Drawn: the school stands beside the families' faith; its silence, gratitude, and care are friendly ground.
- **Judaism.** Core: bal tashchit — do not destroy; shmita — the land's sabbath; Tu B'Shvat — new year of trees. Drawn: rhythm as sacred law; the oldest legal protection of trees in wartime.
- **Islam.** Core: khalifa — trusteeship of the earth; mizan — the balance; planting as charity. Drawn: stewardship as trust held for others; a planted tree as generosity outliving the planter.
- **Biophilia and eco-spirituality.** Core: innate human need for living systems; spirituality as care, not dogma. Drawn: the plainest creed — practical faith, hands in soil, speakable as research and reverence.
- **Deep ecology.** Core: intrinsic worth of the living world; the extended self. Drawn: bridge language for partners arriving through philosophy rather than faith.
- **Rights of nature.** Core: the living world as legal subject — from Te Urewera to Ecuador. Drawn: evidence that the worldview practised with children is where the world is going.

XI. The Ethic of Borrowing

One rule governs the school's relationship to every tradition in this survey, and it is absolute:

The school honours by parallel, never by imitation. It does not perform the ceremonies of other peoples, does not adopt their sacred forms, and does not blend their practices into an unrooted mixture. It practises its *own* place's forms — Hutsul and Ukrainian, under the elders' authority — and recognises, with gratitude and by name, the kin traditions of the world that have walked the same deep structure. Where a teaching from elsewhere informs the school's understanding, it is credited to its people; where a practice belongs to a people, it stays with them. The survey above is a family album, not a catalogue of parts. The school's answer to the world's wisdom is not to borrow its songs but to sing, more faithfully, its own.

Release record

- **Gate 1:** 2026-09-27, the household, recorded by Michel Garand — for publication online as a working draft, open to co-creation and to change.
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